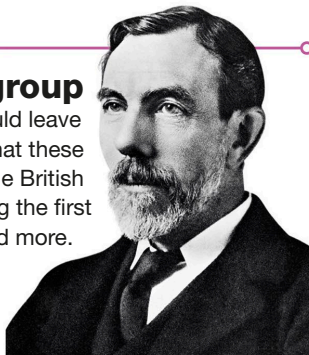


Noble Gases

The elements in the final group of the periodic table are the noble gases. They are called “noble” because these gases do not mix with ordinary elements. The noble gases are very unreactive and their atoms only rarely form chemical bonds with the atoms of other elements.

A new group

In the 1800s, chemists noticed that some reactions would leave behind tiny amounts of unreactive gases. They realized that these gases must be unknown unreactive elements. In 1894, the British chemist Sir William Ramsay purified argon, discovering the first noble gas, and soon found more.



Sir William Ramsay

Colourful plasma

Each element gives off light of a unique colour when heated or electrified. In the 1860s, scientists studying the Sun found a pattern of lights that did not correspond to any element known at that time. They named this unknown element helium, and its pattern was one of the first clues to the existence of noble gases. A mixture of noble gases in a plasma ball will emit unique streaks of light when electrified.

Plasma ball

